



Fitness Watch

Adidas hops onto the fitness watch bandwagon. After seeing Nike's Fuelband SE... Say hello to the MiCoach Smart Run. <http://digit.in/16PH8sf>



M.O.J.O. Baby

Mad Catz is getting ready to launch its new Android gaming microconsole in December. Groovy, baby! <http://digit.in/16hrGS1>

Bazaar

HP Slate 21

Android on this "PC" feels quite good. Nay, very good.

While the design and the form factor is pretty much the standard AIO stuff, there are little elements here and there that make you sit up and take notice of the HP Slate 21. Plastic throughout, but it doesn't look or feel cheap. Very well put together as well, and that makes all the difference. Not a glossy finish by any means, but there is the slight enamel look that lends it that little bit of shine. The same colour theme extends throughout.

The kickstand is rather well built, with the solidity and tautness of the hinge ensuring that the fairly heavy machine remains at exactly the angle you leave it at. The stand allows the screen to tilt back a fair amount as well.

The 21.5-inch screen has an IPS panel, with a Full HD resolution, with multi-touch support complete with gestures. The panel itself is natively bright, with good contrast levels that make this machine excellent for watching movies on. Text readability is brilliant, with very crisp written word on the screen, be it a document or a web browser. The Full HD resolution on a 21.5-inch screen size means there is a lot of real estate for you to work with. The web pages can be resized to nicely fill the width of the display, enhancing readability. Touchscreen works smoothly, adding another way to interact with the product. Also for a display this big, it understands gestures well.

While it may be Android on a touchscreen, using it with a keyboard (and mouse) is made simple by HP – especially the keyboard, which's customized to work with Android, fitted with Home, Back, and other buttons. The travel is good, key size is perfect and the spacing is adequate, but this is where a problem creeps in. The keyboard is noisy, creating a rucuss while typing. Since this is a USB keyboard, you can certainly swap it with a quieter one, if you don't want to upset the house cat.

The Tegra 4 powering this machine is faster than most tablets and smartphones, but not quite in the league of Intel's Core chipset. Benchmark scores were blistering fast, which also included the 3D Mark - Ice Storm graphics benchmark actually giving up, "this benchmark is too light for your machine". From an Android perspective, all the system benchmarks gave out the best scores we have registered. Benchmarks aside, the real world performance is what matters, and the Slate 21 is

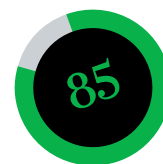


a delight. While going about the daily tasks on the Slate 21, you will hardly feel any slowdown. To see how well it holds up across, we tested the machine with various usage scenarios. First, we had a spreadsheet open, half a dozen tabs in the browser, Google Docs in the dedicated app and still, apps opened without any stutter. Second, we let all these apps remain open in the background, and opened a Full HD movie rip via VLC media player, and skipping through the timeline was smooth as knifing through butter.

One thing is certain, if and when HP does bless the Slate 21 with the Android 4.3 update (currently cycling through various Android 4.2 versions), the performance will only improve because of the wider TRIM support that'll enable better storage performance.

While we are no doubt impressed with this product, don't look at it as a full-fledged Windows desktop replacement. Yes, Android as a full-fledged desktop OS is quite restrictive at times, but it copes very well on a larger form factor, and the product's looks, build and performance are definitely heartening. The only niggle we find with this machine is that there is just 8GB of internal storage – but a memory card or a USB drive can compensate for that with ease. It's a great option to consider for a non-Windows, basic, space-saving touchscreen AIO. Buy this if you need an affordable yet innovative desktop based on Android.

Vishal Mathur



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Specifications

Processor: NVIDIA Tegra Quad-Core T40S; **RAM:** 1GB; **Graphics:** ULP GeForce; **Display:** 21.5-inch IPS (1920 x 1080 pixel) with touchscreen; **Storage:** 8GB + expandable memory; **Connectivity:** 1 USB for external drive, 2 USB for keyboard + mouse, micro SD, 3.5mm jack; **OS:** Android 4.3 (Jelly Bean)

Contact

HP India
Phone: 1243886238
Website: hp.com/in